

FOR FUTURE DADS

Maximize Your *Chances*

FERTILITY CHECKLIST

Your 90-day plan to build healthier sperm and give your future baby a strong start.

Month 1 | Month 2 | Month 3

FOR FUTURE DADS

Fertility is a *team* sport

When a couple plans a pregnancy, most of the attention goes to her. But sperm health matters just as much, and it's something you can actively improve. What you do over the next three months shapes the sperm that could become your future baby.

~74
days for sperm to develop from start to finish

~50%
of couples with fertility problems have **a male factor** involved

90
days of healthier habits can show up in your sperm

How to use this checklist

- ◯ **Start today**
  Every day counts. The sperm you make this week are the ones you'll have in about three months.
- ◯ **Take it one step at a time**
  Five steps, each with clear checkboxes. There's a one-page master checklist at the end.
- ◯ **Bring pages 4–6 to your doctor**
  They cover the checkup, the semen analysis, and medications, so nothing gets missed.
- ◯ **Do it together**
  Your partner's Start Strong PDF guide covers her side. Many steps, like cutting alcohol, are easier as a team.

MYTH

"Fertility is her issue." A male factor plays a role in about half of couples who struggle to conceive.

MYTH

"Men's fertility doesn't change with age." It declines more slowly than women's, but it does decline, especially after 40.

MYTH

"If sex works, my sperm are fine." Sperm problems usually have no symptoms. Only a test can tell.

YOUR PLAN AT A GLANCE

90 days, five *clear* steps

Here's the whole plan on one page. Each step has its own section with details and checkboxes.

STEP 1 · MONTH 1

Get checked

A health checkup, the right tests, and a close look at your medications.

STEP 2 · MONTH 1

Cut what harms sperm

Smoking, alcohol, cannabis, steroids, and too much heat.

STEP 3 · MONTHS 1–3

Build what helps

Weight, movement, sleep, food, and the truth about supplements.

STEP 4 · ONGOING

Be a team player

Share the load, go to appointments together, and keep sex fun.

STEP 5 · MONTH 3 AND BEYOND

Ready to try

Timing, common myths, and when to get checked if it's taking a while.

Book a *men's health* checkup

A visit to your primary care doctor is a good start. If you already know about a fertility-related issue, you can go straight to a urologist.

Before the appointment

- ◯ **Book it this month**
  Some issues take time to fix, and sperm take about 3 months to renew.
- ◯ **List every medication and supplement**
  Including testosterone, gym supplements, and hair-loss treatments.
- ◯ **Know your medical history**
  Undescended testicles, testicle injury or surgery, hernia repair, mumps after puberty, or cancer treatment.
- ◯ **Ask your family about health history**
  Genetic conditions, birth defects, and fertility problems on your side.
- ◯ **Find your vaccination records**
  Especially MMR and hepatitis B.

Checks and tests

- ◯ **Blood pressure, weight, and BMI**
  Your general health is closely linked to your fertility.
- ◯ **Physical exam, including testicles**
  Can spot a varicocele (enlarged veins), a common and treatable cause of lower sperm quality.
- ◯ **STI screening**
  Chlamydia, gonorrhea, HIV, syphilis, and hepatitis B and C. Some affect fertility or can pass to your partner.
- ◯ **Blood sugar**
  Diabetes can affect erections, ejaculation, and sperm.
- ◯ **Carrier screening, if your partner is a carrier**
  If her screening finds a genetic condition, you'll be tested for the same one.

Erection or ejaculation problems? They're common and very treatable. Mention them at your checkup: they're a normal part of fertility care, not something to keep quiet about.

The semen analysis, *demystified*

It's the main fertility test for men: simple, painless, and quick. It checks how many sperm you have, how well they move, and what they look like.

How to prepare

- ◯ **No ejaculation for 2–7 days before**
  Not longer: too many days can lower the quality of the sample.
- ◯ **Collect the whole sample**
  Missing the first part can skew the results.
- ◯ **Use the lab's cup**
  Regular condoms and most lubricants can harm sperm.
- ◯ **Get it to the lab within about an hour**
  If you collect at home, keep it close to body temperature on the way.
- ◯ **Expect a repeat if results are off**
  Results vary a lot. Doctors often repeat the test about a month later.

Reading your results

MEASURE	REFERENCE
Volume	**1.4 mL or more**
Concentration	**16 million/mL or more**
Total sperm count	**39 million or more**
Total motility	**42% or more**
Progressive motility	**30% or more**
Normal shape	**4% or more**

WHO 2021 lower reference limits, based on fertile men. They're not a pass or fail line.

When to do it

If you've tried for 12 months, or 6 months if she's 35 or older. Do it sooner if you have a risk factor from page 4 or have used testosterone or steroids.

Low numbers?

Below-range results don't mean you can't have children. They're a starting point, and many causes can be treated.

Medications and *vaccines*

Some medications can quietly lower sperm production. A quick review with your doctor now can save months later.

Testosterone and steroids: the big one

Testosterone (gels, shots, or pills) and anabolic steroids tell your body to stop making its own. Sperm production can drop sharply or even stop, and recovery can take months after you quit. If you use them, don't just stop: talk to your doctor about fertility-friendly options.

Medications

- ◯ **Review every prescription with your doctor**
  Some medicines for hair loss, bowel disease, blood pressure, or depression may affect sperm. Ask before you change anything.
- ◯ **Check “testosterone boosters” and gym supplements**
  Some contain hidden hormones or steroids.
- ◯ **Talk about long-term pain medication**
  Opioids can lower testosterone and sperm production.

Vaccines

- ◯ **MMR, if you're not immune**
  Mumps after puberty can damage the testicles.
- ◯ **Tdap, if you're not up to date**
  Adults around a newborn should be protected against whooping cough.
- ◯ **Flu and other recommended vaccines**
  Protect your partner during pregnancy and your baby after birth.

Cut what *harms* sperm

These habits have the clearest link to lower sperm quality. The good news: sperm renew constantly, so changes start paying off within a few months.

- ◯ **Quit smoking and vaping**
  Smoking lowers sperm count and movement and damages sperm DNA. Ask your doctor for help quitting.
- ◯ **Keep alcohol light**
  Heavy drinking lowers testosterone and sperm quality. Avoid binge drinking.
- ◯ **Stop cannabis and recreational drugs**
  Regular cannabis use has been linked to lower sperm counts.
- ◯ **No anabolic steroids or testosterone**
  See the previous page. This one matters most.
- ◯ **Keep things cool**
  Skip hot tubs and saunas, and don't rest a laptop on your lap. Sperm develop best a few degrees below body temperature.
- ◯ **Choose looser underwear**
  In one large study, men who mostly wore boxers had higher sperm counts than men in tighter underwear.
- ◯ **Protect yourself from chemicals at work**
  Pesticides, solvents, heavy metals, and radiation. Use protective gear and ask about safer tasks.

Make it a team effort. If she's giving up alcohol while you try, doing it with her makes it easier for both of you.

Build what *helps*

No single food or pill fixes sperm. Solid everyday basics do the heavy lifting.

150 min
of moderate exercise a week

7–9 h
of sleep, when most testosterone is released

5+
servings of vegetables and fruit a day

- ◯ **Aim for a healthy weight**
  Obesity is linked to lower testosterone and sperm quality. Losing even a little weight can help.
- ◯ **Move most days**
  Mix cardio and strength training. Regular, moderate exercise supports healthy hormones.
- ◯ **Protect your sleep**
  Short or irregular sleep can lower testosterone.
- ◯ **Eat Mediterranean-style**
  Vegetables, fruit, whole grains, fish, nuts, and olive oil are linked to better sperm quality.
- ◯ **Cut back on processed meat and sugary drinks**
  Diets high in them are linked to poorer semen quality.
- ◯ **Manage stress**
  Chronic stress can affect hormones and sex drive. Find one outlet that works for you.

The truth about fertility supplements

Skip the pricey “fertility boosters.” In a large 2020 trial, men who took folic acid and zinc for six months didn't have better sperm or more births than men who took a placebo. A standard multivitamin is fine if your diet is limited, but there's no magic pill.

Be a *team* player

Trying for a baby often puts most of the tracking, appointments, and worry on her shoulders. Sharing the load makes the whole journey easier for both of you.

- ◯ **Know her fertile days**
  So she doesn't have to remind you. Ask her to share them from the Mia app.
- ◯ **Go to appointments together**
  Especially the first preconception visit.
- ◯ **Take over the cat litter**
  Toxoplasmosis is a risk for her in pregnancy, not for you.
- ◯ **Change habits together**
  Cutting alcohol or eating better is easier as a team.
- ◯ **Check in every week**
  Ask how she's doing, and share how you're doing, too.
- ◯ **Take the pressure off sex**
  Scheduled sex can kill the mood. Keep it playful, and talk about it openly.

Pressure in bed is normal

Trouble getting or keeping an erection when sex is on a schedule is common. It usually passes. If it doesn't, talk to your doctor: it's treatable.

Stay close as a couple

The **Protect Your Connection** PDF guide has simple tools to keep your relationship strong while you try.

Ready to *try*

A few simple facts help you make the most of every cycle, without turning it into a job.

6
fertile days per cycle: the 5 days before ovulation plus ovulation day

1–2
days between tries during her fertile window is plenty

0
benefit from "saving up." Long breaks don't improve your chances

- ◯ **Have sex every 1–2 days in her fertile window**
  Exact timing to the hour doesn't improve your chances.
- ◯ **Don't save up**
  Going many days without ejaculating doesn't help and can lower sperm quality.
- ◯ **Check your lubricant**
  Many lubricants slow sperm down. Use a fertility-friendly one, or none.
- ◯ **Keep your healthy habits going**
  They count for as long as you're trying.

When to get checked if it's taking a while

She's under 35
after 12 months of trying

She's 35 to 39
after 6 months of trying

She's 40 or older
right away, when you start

Get checked at the same time as your partner. Go sooner if you have a known risk factor.

PRINT ME

Your master *checklist*

Everything on one page. Tick as you go.

Step 1 · Get checked

- ◯ Book a checkup this month
- ◯ List medications and supplements
- ◯ Share your medical history
- ◯ Collect family health history
- ◯ Blood pressure, weight, and blood sugar
- ◯ Physical exam, including testicles
- ◯ STI screening
- ◯ Semen analysis, if advised
- ◯ Carrier screening, if she's a carrier
- ◯ Stop testosterone only with your doctor
- ◯ Update MMR, Tdap, and flu vaccines

Step 2 · Cut

- ◯ Quit smoking and vaping
- ◯ Keep alcohol light
- ◯ Stop cannabis and recreational drugs
- ◯ No steroids or testosterone
- ◯ Skip hot tubs, saunas, laptop on lap
- ◯ Wear looser underwear
- ◯ Protect yourself from chemicals

Step 3 · Build

- ◯ Aim for a healthy weight
- ◯ Exercise 150 minutes a week
- ◯ Sleep 7–9 hours
- ◯ Eat Mediterranean-style
- ◯ Skip pricey fertility boosters

Step 4 · Team

- ◯ Know her fertile days
- ◯ Go to appointments together
- ◯ Take over the cat litter
- ◯ Check in every week

Step 5 · Try

- ◯ Sex every 1–2 days in her window
- ◯ Don't save up
- ◯ Use a fertility-friendly lubricant
- ◯ Know when to get checked

Notes for your *checkup*

Keep going together

Your partner's side of the prep is in the **Start Strong** PDF guide, and the **Protect Your Connection** PDF guide helps you stay close as a couple. For more helpful information about getting ready for pregnancy, explore the Mia app together.

Sources

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This checklist is for general education and isn't medical advice. Talk to your doctor about what's right for you.